

Deepa Palaniappan

Disability Inclusion & Accessibility | Policy, Research and Capacity Building | Government and International Organisations

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PROFILE

Disability inclusion, accessibility and policy professional with over a decade of experience across government, United Nations and World Bank systems, academia and grassroots practice. Named contributor to the WHO Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities (2022). Developed the Bihar State Disability Inclusion Guideline, in implementation since 2020, and is currently one of two members of the committee drafting the Tamil Nadu State Disability Policy. Assistant Professor at Azim Premji University, and consultant to the WHO Disability Unit, Geneva (two assignments) and the World Bank. IAAP-certified accessibility professional (CPACC) with applied expertise in assistive technology, document accessibility and built-environment accessibility, and founder of the Disability Rights Repository and EquitableDocs initiatives.

EDUCATION

- **Mid-career Master's in Development Studies**, Graduate Institute Geneva (IHEID), full scholarship, 2019 to 2021. Thesis: case study on the National Rural Livelihoods Mission and disability inclusion.
- **MA and MPhil, Political Science, Jawaharlal Nehru University**. MPhil dissertation: "Approaches to Disability: Norms, Discourse and Policy".
- **UGC NET qualified, Political Science**.
- **PG Diploma in Special Education (Neurological Disorders and Multiple Disabilities)**, University of Delhi.

AREAS OF EXPERTISE

- Disability policy: drafting, analysis and review
- Disability-inclusive development and mainstreaming
- Accessibility: digital, document and built-environment
- Assistive technology solutions and advisory
- Training, capacity building and curriculum development
- Research, documentation and report writing
- Reasonable accommodation and legal frameworks
- Multi-stakeholder and inter-governmental coordination
- Large public-events accessibility planning and implementation
- Disability data, informatics and standards (Bureau of Indian Standards)

INITIATIVES

- **Disability Rights Repository**. disability-rights-repository.org. Developed and maintains a web portal that builds the documentation capabilities of organisations of persons with disabilities, OPD leaders and patient advocates, and creates visibility for community-based grassroots practitioners.
- **EquitableDocs**. equitabledocs.org. Founder of a document equity initiative providing accessible-document remediation for students at no cost and capacity-building partnerships for universities, with a Global South focus.

PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

Assistant Professor, then Consultant

Office of Disability Inclusion, Azim Premji University · Assistant Professor Dec 2022 to Jul 2025; Consultant Jul 2025 to present

- Taught and developed course content; led reasonable-accommodation, disability-inclusion and accessibility interventions across the University.
- Designed and delivered training and faculty-development sessions; liaised with faculty, departments and external experts.

Consultant

World Health Organization HQ, Disability Unit, Geneva (two assignments) · Oct 2021 to Sep 2022; Aug 2023 to Dec 2023

- Named contributor to the [WHO Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities \(2022\)](https://www.who.int/publications/m/item/global-report-on-health-equity-for-persons-with-disabilities-2022): scoping review on health emergencies and disability, and analysis of disability inclusion in national health and disability policies.
- Reviewed WHO documents for disability-inclusion components; mapped organisations of persons with disabilities across countries; coordinated stakeholder consultations including sign-language interpretation.

Consultant

World Bank / Government of Tamil Nadu (TN RIGHTS Project) · Project consultancy 2021 to 2022; State Disability Policy drafting committee 2026 to present

- Initiated and facilitated a CBR core group and multi-stakeholder consultations; drafted a CBR policy and supported the State implementation plan and accessibility inputs.
- Currently a member of the two-person committee drafting the Tamil Nadu State Disability Policy.

Consultant

UN OHCHR (mandate of the UN Special Rapporteur) · May to Jun 2022

- Compiled and analysed disability and leprosy-inclusion policies globally; submitted a research report with a Global South focus.

State Disability Consultant

Govt of Bihar (JEEVIKA / State Rural Livelihoods Mission), Govt of Odisha (OLM), Sightsavers India · 2016 to 2021

- Mainstreamed disability inclusion across a state poverty-alleviation programme; built convergence channels with state and central government departments.
- Developed the State Disability Inclusion guideline (in implementation since 2020); designed and delivered training for district, block and state officials.

Research roles

SDRS New Delhi (Research Fellow); International Disability Alliance, Geneva (Research Intern); VSO India · 2013 to 2017

- Field and policy research; co-authored a study on inclusive curriculum in Government Industrial Training Institutes for a UNICEF-sponsored publication.

CURRICULUM, TRAINING MATERIALS AND DOCUMENTATION

- Developed the State Disability Inclusion Guideline for the Bihar State Rural Livelihoods Mission, in implementation since 2020.
- Developed training modules, session plans and orientation curricula for Odisha Livelihoods Mission and Bihar SRLM staff.
- Co-authored a situational study on inclusive curriculum in Government Industrial Training Institutes (UNICEF-sponsored publication).
- Named contributor, [WHO Global Report on Health Equity for Persons with Disabilities \(2022\)](#).
- Drafted a CBR policy and implementation inputs for the World Bank TN RIGHTS project; member of the committee drafting the Tamil Nadu State Disability Policy (2026).

SELECTED TRAINING AND CAPACITY-BUILDING DELIVERY

- District-level training for Rural Development officials across 13+ Bihar districts (Jeevika / SRLM).
- State Resource Person: video-conference training for 26 district and block officials, Government of Bihar (Department of Social Welfare).
- Key Resource Person: orientation for Block and State officials, Odisha Livelihoods Mission, SIRD Bhubaneswar.
- Resource Person: State-level DPO training-cum-workshop, Jharkhand State Livelihoods Promotion Society and Sightsavers.
- Resource Person: consultation workshop on inclusive TVET curriculum in ITIs, Regional Vocational Training Institute, Bangalore (VSO India).
- Faculty Development Workshop, Mangalore University (2025); seven-day workshop on accessibility, NIT Rourkela (2025); pre-conference workshop, BITS Hyderabad (2025).
- Resource Person: IGNOU workshop for Deputy and Assistant Registrars and Section Officers.
- Financial Inclusion training for bank managers on RBI inclusive-banking guidelines, Nalanda district.
- Resource Person and keynote speaker, International Symposium, NIT Rourkela (2025).

PUBLICATIONS

- [“Enabling Policies”](#), Yojana Development Journal, Government of India (Publications Division), December 2020.

- Friedner, M., Ghosh, N., and Palaniappan, D., “‘[Cross-Disability](#)’ in India? On the Limits of Disability as a Category”, South Asia Multidisciplinary Academic Journal.
- Palaniappan, D., and Rodrigues, V., “Disability within the Rawlsian Framework of Justice”, in A. Ghai (Ed.), [Disability in South Asia: Knowledge and Experience](#), Sage Publications, 2018.
- Palaniappan, D., and Guru, P., “Skill Training for Adolescents with Disabilities: Government Industrial Training Institutes in Jharkhand”, in Sonpal and Vaishnav (Eds.), Empowering Children with Disabilities (UNICEF-sponsored).
- “[Inner Marginalities and Sub-Group Politicization within the Disability Movement](#)”, Cafe Dissensus, August 2016.
- Book Review, International Journal of Disability Studies, Vol. 9, No. 1-2, 2015, SDRS Publications.
- “ICT4D and Accessibility: ICT-based Development Projects and Tools for Rural Communities in India”, Conference Proceedings, National Symposium, ICAR-CIAE Bhopal, 2016.

CONFERENCE ENGAGEMENT

- Invited panellist, “Disability Justice: Looking Beyond Ableist Frames”, IDSK Kolkata, 2024.
- Invited speaker, National Conference on State, Society and Disability Law, University of Hyderabad.
- Invited panellist, University of Chicago (Delhi Centre) Round Table, New Delhi.
- Session Chair, National Conference on Access to Higher Education, Jawaharlal Nehru University, 2015.
- Panellist and panel moderator, World Health Innovation Forum, AMTZ Visakhapatnam, 2024 and 2025.

A detailed list of conference papers presented, panels chaired and workshops conducted is available on request.

FELLOWSHIPS, CERTIFICATIONS AND COMMITTEES

- SYLFF Fellow (Ryoichi Sasakawa Young Leaders Fellowship Fund), JNU, 2010 to 2013 (doctoral research).
- Distinguished Fellow, Kalam Institute of Health Technology (WHO Collaborating Centre), 2023 to 2025.
- Sarai-CSDS Student Stipend Award, 2005 to 2006.
- Certified Professional in Accessibility Core Competencies (CPACC), IAAP.
- Certified Disability Rights and Accessibility Consultant, US Institute of Diplomacy and Human Rights, Washington DC.
- Member, Disability Informatics Sub-Committee, Bureau of Indian Standards, Government of India.
- Ex-General Council Member, NIEPID (nominated by the Ministry of Social Justice and Empowerment).
- Technical Committee Member, Purple Building Certification Scheme (accessibility rating for public buildings).
- Certificate Programme in Assistive Technology (6 months), NISH Trivandrum; DEI programme (FICCI); CII-IBDN Disability Inclusive Leaders; WHO QualityRights training.